

“WHY DOES NOT THE POPE... BUILD... ST. PETER’S WITH HIS OWN MONEY, RATHER THAN WITH THE MONEY... OF POOR BELIEVERS.”

Martin Luther, German priest, from *95 Theses*, 1517

THE OTTOMAN CONQUESTS IN THE MIDDLE EAST under **Selim I**—who in 1517 also brought Algeria into the Ottoman orbit—meant that the Ottoman Turkish state was now emphatically an **empire**. It was also rapidly developing as a major naval power. Control of Egypt both consolidated the Ottoman presence in the eastern Mediterranean and, crucially, gave them access to the Red Sea. Already effectively masters of the overland trade routes with the East, the Ottomans were now poised to dominate the lucrative “route of spices.” In doing so, they found themselves in direct conflict with the Portuguese, who had been actively probing the Red Sea since 1513. The stage was set for another round of conflict between the Muslim world and the Christian West.

In October 1517, the priest and professor of theology **Martin Luther** (1483–1546) nailed his *95 Theses* to the door of All Saints

Church in Wittenberg, Saxony, as part of what was a growing protest movement against religious practices and corruption in the Catholic Church. In 1521, after being excommunicated by the pope, his opposition to the Church hardened. The ready response to Luther’s teachings and the influence of the printing press (see pp.154–55) in disseminating his ideas resulted in a major force for religious change known as the **Reformation**.

The arrival of a **Portuguese fleet** under Tomé Pires in **Canton, China**, in August 1517 was the climax of a campaign to open up trading routes across the Indian Ocean, begun when Vasco da Gama rounded the Cape of Good Hope in 1498. However, the early results of these encounters were not promising, as the Chinese regarded the newcomers as **uncouth barbarians**. A Portuguese trade mission to Peking in 1520 was treated with similar scorn.



The fall of Tenochtitlán on August 13, 1521 was the result not just of Spanish ferocity but of a 20,000-strong native army recruited by Hernán Cortés.

THE ELECTION OF CHARLES V AS HOLY ROMAN EMPEROR in 1519 appeared pivotal. Charles (1500–58) was already the ruler of several territories across Europe: in Italy, Austria, the Low Countries, and in Spain. Now, as Holy Roman Emperor, his status appeared unassailable. For the earnest Charles, the imperatives were clear—to preside over a prosperous, pan-European Catholic entity which, properly mobilized, would then **route the Ottoman menace**. The reality was painfully different. The size of his territories made effective control impossible. Few of his subjects were prepared to surrender traditional “liberties” to a distant, foreign ruler; almost none was prepared to finance him; and religious differences persistently intruded. Simultaneously, the prospect of Habsburg domination alarmed every other major European power, above all France. The result was a **reign of near**



Emperor Charles V

Few rulers were more dutiful than Charles V or as conscious of their divine destiny. However, his best efforts consistently proved in vain.

permanent warfare and dutiful hopes consistently frustrated.

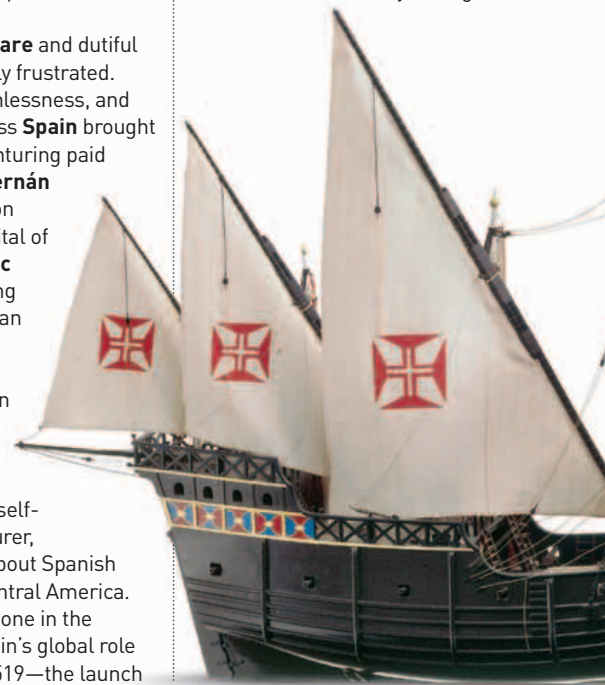
The daring, ruthlessness, and single-mindedness **Spain** brought to overseas adventuring paid dividends with **Hernán Cortés’s** march on Tenochtitlán, capital of the Mexican **Aztec Empire**. Beginning in 1519, in less than five years the Spanish force, aided by Tlaxaclan warriors, had subjugated an entire nation. A minor noble and self-financing adventurer, Cortés brought about Spanish domination of Central America.

A further milestone in the cementing of Spain’s global role was marked in 1519—the launch

“HE KNEW BETTER THAN ANY OTHER THE TRUE ART OF NAVIGATION.”

Antonio Pigafetta, Italian navigator, on Ferdinand Magellan, 1521

of the **first circumnavigation of the globe**. The expedition leader, **Ferdinand Magellan** (b. 1480) was a Portuguese nobleman who, despite his nationality, succeeded in persuading Charles V to bankroll his scheme to reach the Spice Islands in the Pacific by sailing



THE REFORMATION

The Reformation—the religious revolt against the Catholic Church instigated by Martin Luther (right)—tore the Western Church apart. Politics intruded from the start as the revolt spread across Europe. The consequence was a legacy of violent religious division and confrontation between Catholics and Protestants that led to a permanent divide in European Christendom.

